

THE MICHAEL THORNE SERIES - BOOK FOUR

The Hollow Witness

A Psychological Crime Thriller

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READING SAMPLE

Publisher Edition 2026

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About this reading sample

This reading sample contains a continuous excerpt from the beginning of *The Hollow Witness*. It is based on the edition identified on the cover. The text below is drawn from the manuscript and is not the complete book.

Excerpt length: approximately 5,155 words.

PROLOGUE

THE MISSING LINE

* * *

Marian Cope knew the visitor had read her transcript because he used the word she had removed.

Not corrected.

Removed.

He stood inside the kitchen with rain darkening the shoulders of his coat and a clear plastic folder beneath one arm. The folder contained a copy of testimony Marian had typed seven years earlier in a county hearing room that no longer existed.

She had been sixty-one then.

She was sixty-eight now, diabetic, recently widowed and tired of discovering that records could remain dangerous long after the people named in them had retired.

"You should not have this," she said.

The visitor placed the folder on the table.

"Neither should you."

The kitchen clock showed 9:17 p.m.

Marian had not invited him to sit.

He did anyway.

The chair faced the window above the sink. His reflection appeared in the black glass, but the hood of his coat and the light behind him prevented her from seeing enough of his face to remember later.

If there was a later.

The thought arrived without panic.

Years of court reporting had taught her that fear did not always announce itself as fear. Sometimes it appeared as an unnecessary observation. A wet sleeve. A shoe placed too squarely against the tile. A man who knew where the spoons were kept because he had already opened the drawer.

Marian remained beside the counter.

"What do you want?"

He opened the folder.

The first page carried the title from the old proceeding.

IN RE: PROTECTIVE CUSTODY OF UNIDENTIFIED WITNESS 14-B

The caption had been false.

The woman had a name.

Tessa Ward.

The county had known it.

The officers had known it.

Marian had known it while she typed every answer and watched an assistant state's attorney replace the woman's name with a number before the transcript was certified.

The visitor turned to page forty-seven.

A yellow tab marked the margin.

"Read the final question," he said.

"No."

"You remember it."

"I remember many things I do not repeat to strangers."

He looked up.

The hood did not move.

"You repeated it once."

Marian glanced toward the telephone mounted beside the refrigerator.

Too far.

Her mobile phone was charging in the bedroom.

The visitor noticed the glance and did nothing.

That made the distance worse.

"The transcript was sealed," she said.

"The transcript was shortened."

"By court order."

"By you."

Marian felt anger before fear.

"I typed what they allowed me to certify."

"That is not the same as what you heard."

He was right.

The hearing had lasted four hours and twelve minutes.

The certified transcript contained three hours and fifty-one.

Twenty-one minutes disappeared between a question about the farmhouse door and the witness's first description of Michael Thorne.

Marian had retained the raw steno notes because the deletion felt like participation.

She had never shown them to police.

She had shown them to one attorney.

Ruth Calder.

The woman now holding the original recording Tessa made inside the farmhouse.

The visitor tapped page forty-seven.

"What did Ward say after the question was removed?"

"Ask her."

"I am asking you."

"Then you have the wrong witness."

His right hand moved beneath the table.

Marian heard a soft plastic click.

Not a gun.

Something smaller.

He placed an insulin pen beside the folder.

It was the same brand she used.

The label carried her prescription number.

"Where did you get that?"

"From your refrigerator."

Marian looked toward the small white appliance behind him.

The door remained closed.

Her own pen lay inside, or had when she checked before dinner.

"You were here before."

"No."

"Then someone was."

He did not answer.

Marian understood the arrangement.

He wanted the room to suggest that she had administered the wrong dose. A woman alone. A chronic condition. A recently refilled prescription. No forced entry.

The death would not look impossible.

Only sufficient.

"You cannot make me sign anything," she said.

"I do not need your signature."

"Then why are you here?"

"To know whether the missing line still exists outside the recording."

Marian looked at the transcript.

The question before the removed section remained visible.

DID DETECTIVE THORNE APPEAR DISORIENTED WHEN HE LEFT THE ROOM?

The certified answer read:

I COULD NOT SEE HIS FACE.

That was not the first answer Tessa Ward had given.

The first answer was longer.

Marian remembered every word because she had stopped typing after hearing it.

"She said he did not look confused," Marian said.

The visitor remained still.

"Continue."

"She said he looked relieved."

Rain struck the kitchen window.

The visitor's reflection did not change.

"Relieved by what?"

Marian thought of Tessa in the hearing room, wrists marked by old restraint bruises, speaking toward a judge who never once used her name.

"By leaving," Marian said.

"That is interpretation."

"No. It was her answer."

"What else?"

Marian could lie.

The visitor would know.

Or pretend to.

"She said Thorne paused at the door and told the other man, 'I will remember why. I do not need to remember how.'"

The visitor lowered his head.

The sentence mattered to him.

Not because it was new.

Because it survived.

"Who was the other man?" he asked.

"The transcript never identified him."

"Did Ward?"

"Not then."

"Later?"

Marian said nothing.

The visitor reached for the insulin pen.

She stepped backwards.

The counter pressed against her spine.

"Ruth has the original," Marian said.

The hand stopped.

"Ruth Calder?"

Marian regretted the name immediately.

Not because the visitor had learned it.

Because his lack of reaction showed he already knew.

"What did Calder preserve?" he asked.

"You came here knowing that."

"I came here knowing she held a container."

"Then leave."

"What is inside?"

"A recording."

"Only a recording?"

Marian looked toward the folder.

The visitor followed her eyes.

He turned to the final page.

The certification block carried Marian's old signature.

Below it, someone had typed a second line that had not been there seven years earlier.

WITNESS STATUS: HOLLOW

Marian stared at the word.

"What does that mean?"

"It means the testimony remains after the corroboration is removed."

"That is not a legal status."

"It became one."

The visitor stood.

Marian moved towards the telephone.

He did not rush.

He caught her wrist before she reached it and pressed the pen against the inside of her arm.

The needle entered through her sleeve.

She struck him with her free hand.

Her fingers found skin beneath the hood.

A scar.

Narrow and raised.

He released the dose.

Marian pulled away.

The pen fell to the floor.

"How much?" she asked.

He placed the transcript back inside the folder.

"Enough to make the first conclusion easy."

Her heart beat hard.

Insulin would not act immediately.

She had minutes.

Perhaps more.

The telephone remained within reach.

The visitor saw her calculating.

He lifted the receiver from its cradle and laid it on the counter.

No dial tone.

The cord had been cut.

"You do not have to do this," Marian said.

"I already did."

He turned towards the hallway.

"Who opened the farmhouse door?" Marian asked.

He stopped.

She had found the question that still controlled him.

"Tessa never knew," Marian continued. "Neither did Thorne."

The visitor faced her again.

"Do you?"

Marian's vision had begun to narrow.

She reached for the edge of the table.

"I know whose shoes crossed the threshold."

"Name."

"Call an ambulance."

"Name."

"Ambulance first."

He considered the exchange.

For one second Marian believed he might accept.

Then he moved the kitchen chair away from her.

Not towards the door.

Away from the telephone and the glucose tablets on the counter.

The action was small.

Deliberate.

Familiar.

Marian sank to the tile.

The visitor crouched beside her.

"Who opened the door?"

Her mouth had become dry.

She thought of Tessa Ward refusing to let a sealed transcript become the only version of her life.

She thought of Ruth Calder and the container beneath three signatures.

She thought of a detective who had left a bound woman in a room because she was not the person he had come to judge.

Marian smiled.

"The witness," she said.

The visitor waited for more.

None came.

He left through the back door.

At 10:02 p.m., Marian's neighbour noticed the kitchen light and the rain entering through the open doorway.

By then, the visitor had removed page forty-seven.

He left the insulin pen beneath Marian's hand.

He did not find the raw steno notes.

They were inside the chair he moved.

CHAPTER 1

THE WOMAN WHO WAS NOT THE SUBJECT

* * *

Elena met Tessa Ward in a federal interview room with no reflective glass.

That condition came from Tessa.

The room had one door, one table and four visible cameras mounted above the corners. A fifth device sat on the table to create an independent recording for Tessa's attorney.

No one observed from behind a wall.

Special Agent Priya Desai sat beside Elena.

Daniel Hargrove sat beside his client.

Tessa chose the chair facing the door.

She was forty-one, with dark hair cut above the shoulders and a pale line along the right side of her jaw. The scar was visible only when she turned towards the overhead light.

She had worn no jewellery.

No watch.

Her hands rested flat on the table.

Elena had reviewed the protection conditions before entering.

No photograph identification.

No confrontation with Michael.

No recording played beyond the portions Tessa selected until a court established handling terms for the original.

No questions about her current address, employment or family.

The two recent deaths would be investigated independently before anyone claimed a connection.

Elena agreed to every condition.

Tessa had added one more.

Michael Thorne's name could be used.

The Curator could not.

"That is his word," Tessa said. "Not mine."

The interview began at 8:12 the next morning.

Rain remained on the windows of the federal building. Water darkened the shoulders of Hargrove's wool coat where he had carried it through the lobby.

Elena stated the date, time and names present.

Tessa corrected one detail.

"Protected reference number first."

Elena read it into the record.

TW-0417.

Only after that did she say Tessa's name.

"Thank you," Tessa said.

Elena opened a new notebook.

The cover contained no category.

"Your attorney contacted me because you have information concerning two recent deaths and an incident seven years ago," Elena said.

"Yes."

"We will treat those as separate until evidence connects them."

"They are connected."

"What makes you believe that?"

Tessa looked towards Hargrove.

He did not answer for her.

"Both people heard what Michael said at the farmhouse," she said.

"Directly?"

"One did. One heard my testimony before the record was shortened."

"Names."

"Evan Slade and Marian Cope."

Desai opened a file.

Evan Slade, sixty-four, former McHenry County deputy sheriff.

Dead eleven days earlier from carbon monoxide exposure in a detached garage.

The medical examiner found no trauma. The automatic door had failed to open. Slade's truck remained running.

No criminal investigation had been opened.

Marian Cope, sixty-eight, retired court reporter.

Found dead the previous night in her kitchen. Initial field assessment suggested accidental insulin overdose.

The medical examiner had not completed toxicology.

The proximity in time was concerning.

It was not yet proof.

"When did you learn Marian was dead?" Elena asked.

"This morning."

"From whom?"

"Ruth Calder."

"Who is she?"

"The attorney who preserved the original recording."

Hargrove placed a sealed letter on the table.

"This confirms Ms. Calder's custodial role without disclosing the storage location," he said.

Desai did not touch it.

"We will receive it through evidence intake," she said.

Hargrove nodded.

The letter remained where he placed it.

Elena looked at Tessa.

"Start with the farmhouse."

Tessa's hands stayed flat.

"I was thirty-four. I worked for Lucas Fenner."

"County auditor?"

"State contract investigator. The newspapers called him an auditor because it was easier. He followed money from property seizures into private legal funds."

"Whose funds?"

"Three counties. Two sheriff associations. A judicial campaign account."

"Did the investigation concern Hale or Ascension?"

"Not that I knew."

"Michael believed it did?"

"Michael believed a file Lucas carried contained an interview from St. Vincent."

Naomi Bell.

Crowne's method.

The years before Claire Liang.

Michael had moved through several private investigations during that period, using his badge when useful and hiding his access when it was not.

"What happened to Lucas Fenner?" Elena asked.

"He was shot in a parking structure in Rockford."

"Arrest?"

"A contractor named Wesley Crane. The charges were dismissed after evidence contamination."

"Was Crane guilty?"

"I do not know."

The answer arrived without decoration.

"What did you witness?"

"Lucas gave me a red file and told me to take it to Caleb Morrow. I drove to the farmhouse because Caleb maintained the property. Two men stopped me before I reached the porch."

"Police?"

"One wore a county jacket. Neither showed identification."

"Did they restrain you?"

"Plastic cuffs. Ankles and wrists."

"Inside the farmhouse?"

"Front room."

"How long before Michael arrived?"

"About two hours."

"How did you know the time?"

"The wall clock worked."

"Did you know Michael then?"

"No."

"Did he identify himself?"

"He showed a badge. I saw the name."

"Could you read it clearly?"

"Yes."

"You have since seen extensive reporting about him. That affects any visual identification now."

"I am not asking you to accept a visual identification now."

"What are you asking us to accept?"

Tessa looked towards the small digital recorder Hargrove had placed between them.

"His voice. The watch. The words."

"Describe the watch without playing the recording."

"Metal case. Chain. He opened it repeatedly. The glass was cracked across the lower half."

Michael's pocket watch had been recovered during his arrest.

Its glass was repaired but the original fracture line remained documented in academy photographs and in Morrison's statement.

"What time did it show?" Elena asked.

"Two seventeen."

Elena wrote the answer.

Tessa watched her.

"You knew that already."

"I knew Michael used that time. I did not know you saw it."

"He wanted me to see it."

"Why?"

"Because he thought a fixed time made the room easier to control."

"Did he say that?"

"No."

"Then that is your interpretation."

Tessa's mouth changed slightly.

Approval, perhaps.

"Yes," she said. "It is."

Elena kept the distinction in the record.

"What did Michael want from you?"

"The red file."

"Did you have it?"

"Not by then."

"Where was it?"

"Caleb had taken it from the car before the men brought me inside."

"Did Michael believe you?"

"No."

"Did he question you?"

"For three hours."

"Threats?"

"No direct threat."

"Physical contact?"

"He checked the restraints. He moved the chair twice. He gave me water."

"Did he release you?"

"No."

"Did you ask?"

"Many times."

"What did he say?"

Tessa's fingers lifted from the table.

Only for a second.

Then returned.

"At first, he said he did not know who had placed me there. Then he said release would alter the account."

"Exact words?"

"Not the first time."

"Later?"

"Later he said, 'You are not the subject.'"

The sentence entered the room without volume.

Hargrove watched Elena.

Desai watched Tessa.

"What did you understand that to mean?" Elena asked.

"That he had come for someone else."

"Who?"

"Caleb. Or Lucas's file. Michael used the words as though a person and a document could occupy the same role."

"Did he harm you?"

Tessa looked directly at Elena.

"He left me restrained."

"I am asking because later legal arguments may separate action from omission."

"Then record both. He did not put the cuffs on me. He did not inject me. He did not strike me. He moved my chair away from the door after I showed him I could reach the handle with my foot. Then he left."

Elena wrote each act separately.

"Did he seek help?"

"No."

"How do you know?"

"No one came until the next morning."

"Who came?"

"I do not know."

"Male or female?"

"I heard boots. The person cut the restraints from behind the chair and left before I could turn."

"Why did you not see them?"

"A hood had been placed over my head after Michael left."

"By Michael?"

"No."

"How can you be certain?"

"The watch had stopped ticking. The second person smelled of motor oil and peppermint. Michael smelled like wet wool and soap."

Sensory memory.

Potentially accurate.

Potentially shaped by repetition.

Still evidence to test.

"When did you make the recording?" Elena asked.

"A dictation device was sewn into my document bag. Lucas used it for field notes. It started when one of the men searched the bag and pressed the slide switch."

"Continuous?"

"Ruth says the original contains four hours and six minutes."

"Have you listened to all of it?"

"Once."

"When?"

"Seven years ago."

"Never since?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because I knew what happened. I did not need to keep hearing myself ask."

Hargrove moved his hand near the recorder but did not stop it.

Tessa continued.

"The authorities took a copy. The copy entered a sealed protective-custody hearing. Twenty-one minutes were removed from the transcript. The audio was later described as incomplete. Ruth kept the original."

"Why did she not disclose it to law enforcement?"

"She tried. The prosecutor obtained an order placing it under review because it allegedly contained protected source material from an unrelated police investigation."

"Michael's investigation."

"Yes."

"Did Michael know the original survived?"

"I do not know."

"Why contact me now?"

"Because Evan called me before he died."

Desai looked up.

"You did not tell your attorney that."

"I told him I received a call. I did not say what Evan said."

Hargrove did not appear surprised.

He had allowed his client to control the first disclosure.

"What did he say?" Elena asked.

"He said someone had requested the farmhouse evidence under Michael's old case number."

"Which number?"

Tessa recited it.

Elena recognized the prefix.

A homicide auxiliary file opened during the Gabriel Shaw investigation.

The case number had been closed, then sealed, then included in discovery for Michael's prosecution.

Someone using it now would either possess access to protected police data or expect clerks to recognize the authority attached to his name.

"Did Evan identify the requester?"

"No. He said the signature was electronic and the employee number belonged to a dead detective."

"When was the call?"

"The night before he died."

"Recording?"

"No."

"Telephone records?"

"My attorney preserved them."

Hargrove nodded.

"Why did Evan contact you rather than police?" Elena asked.

"Because he had been one of the men who put me in the farmhouse."

The answer altered the room.

"Evan Slade restrained you?"

"He drove the county vehicle. He said the other man ordered it."

"When did he admit that?"

"Three years ago."

"To you directly?"

"Yes."

"Witness?"

"Ruth."

"Written statement?"

"Unsigned. Evan said he would sign if Caleb Morrow confirmed who ordered the detention. Caleb disappeared before the meeting."

"When?"

"Six weeks later."

"Missing-person report?"

"Closed after a bank withdrawal in Indiana."

"You think he is alive."

"I think someone wanted the record to show movement."

Elena closed her notebook.

Not because the interview was finished.

Because the next question required a clean line.

"Do you believe Michael Thorne killed Evan Slade or Marian Cope?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"He is in custody."

"He has influenced events from custody before."

"Then I will say it more carefully. I have no evidence Michael caused either death."

"Do you believe the deaths are intended to protect him?"

"I do not know."

"Do you want the recording used in his trial?"

Tessa took time before answering.

"I want the recording used wherever it belongs."

"That includes his trial."

"Yes."

"Even if disclosing it identifies you publicly?"

Hargrove shifted.

Tessa did not.

"My name was already removed once," she said. "I will not let protection become another removal."

Elena understood the demand.

Not publicity.

Ownership.

"You asked to play one section," Elena said.

Tessa looked towards Hargrove.

He opened a hard case on the floor and removed a small digital player.

Not the original.

A verified copy created by Ruth Calder under a private evidence protocol whose validity would still need independent review.

Hargrove placed it on the table.

"Fifty-three seconds," he said. "No duplication today."

Desai stated the limitation for the record.

Tessa pressed play.

Static filled the room.

A clock sounded in the distance.

Then Tessa's younger voice.

"Please open the door."

A man answered.

Michael.

No distortion.

No shouting.

The controlled voice Elena had heard in interviews, in private recordings and across a table after he stopped claiming that every missing hour belonged to someone else.

"If Martinez sees the room, she will open the door," he said.
"If she hears only the witness, she will preserve the room."

Tessa said, "Who is Martinez?"

A metallic lid clicked shut.

Tick.

Pause.

Tick.

"Someone who still believes the difference matters,"
Michael said.

"What difference?"

"Between leaving you and choosing you."

The recording ended.

No one spoke immediately.

Elena looked at Tessa.

"Seven years ago, Michael knew my name."

"Yes."

"Were we partners?"

"He said you had worked three cases together."

Their partnership had begun seven years earlier.

Three cases.

Early enough that Elena still mistook his precision for transparency.

"Why did he mention me?" she asked.

"Because I asked whether any good officer would leave me there."

"And that was his answer?"

"Part of it."

"What was the rest?"

Tessa pressed her hands flat again.

"He said a good officer would open the door."

"And?"

"A useful one would wait to learn what was behind it."

Elena heard the distinction Michael had lived by.

Goodness as identity.

Usefulness as permission.

"Which did he say he was?"

Tessa looked at the silent player.

"He said he had stopped asking."

At 10:06, the interview paused.

Desai stepped into the corridor and requested emergency preservation orders for the Slade and Cope deaths, the old

farmhouse file and every access log connected to Michael's auxiliary case number.

Elena remained inside.

Tessa watched the door.

"You opened it," she said.

"Which door?"

"This one."

"That is not the same room."

"No."

Tessa looked towards the four visible cameras.

"That is why I came."

CHAPTER 2

THE FARMHOUSE FILE

* * *

The official farmhouse file contained one hundred and eighty-six pages.

The access history contained more.

Elena read both inside a secure review room while Desai traced the federal requests and Wells examined the police side of Michael's old case number.

No one called the file hollow.

The word appeared only once, in a metadata field added eighteen months after the protective-custody hearing.

WITNESS STATUS: HOLLOW

No author.

No policy reference.

No definition.

The field had migrated through three database conversions without being removed.

"Could be a corrupted value," the records analyst said.

"Could be," Elena answered.

The analyst waited.

Elena did not ask him to choose.

"Find the first system in which it appears."

"That database was retired."

"Retired is not destroyed."

"Sometimes it is."

"Then document which."

He nodded and returned to the terminal.

The farmhouse stood outside Hebron, Illinois, six miles south of the Wisconsin line.

Official ownership belonged to Fenner Agricultural Holdings.

Lucas Fenner's brother had inherited it, then transferred it to a creditor after the murder.

The county used the property twice under an informal witness-stabilization agreement.

No contract authorized detention.

No order named Tessa Ward.

The report described her as a voluntary source waiting for transport.

Photographs showed plastic ties on the floor.

The evidence inventory listed them as packaging material.

Evan Slade signed the inventory.

Marian Cope typed the later hearing.

Ruth Calder challenged the sealed transcript.

Caleb Morrow never testified.

Four people around the same omission.

Two dead.

One missing for seven years.

One holding the original recording.

Elena wrote the sequence on paper.

She did not place Michael in the centre.

His name belonged beside the three-hour period he occupied the room.

Nothing more.

Nothing less.

Wells entered carrying a printout.

He wore the same navy tie he had worn during Halliday's courthouse operation. A salt line marked the edge of his left shoe.

"The request Slade saw was real," he said.

"Authorized?"

"No."

"Credentials?"

"Detective Arthur Meech. Dead nine years."

"Department?"

"Rockford."

"Connection to Michael?"

"Meech's employee number was included in Gabriel Shaw discovery because he transported sealed interview material in 2018."

"Who could see it?"

"Prosecution, defence, court personnel, evidence staff, outside experts approved under protective order."

"Number."

"Forty-two individuals, plus system administrators."

Not a suspect list.

An access universe.

"Request source?"

"County network terminal in Woodstock. Public records floor. No camera at the terminal. Building entrance camera retained thirty days. Request was thirty-four days ago."

"Convenient."

"Predictable."

The distinction mattered.

A person who knew retention policy did not need extraordinary access.

Only patience.

"What did the request retrieve?" Elena asked.

"Farmhouse photographs, hearing caption, current custodian reference for sealed media."

"Ruth Calder's name?"

"Not storage location."

"Tessa's protected identity?"

"Reference number only."

"Caleb Morrow?"

"Last known file address."

"Which was false after the Indiana withdrawal."

"Probably."

Wells placed a second page beside the first.

"Michael accessed the same file seven years ago."

"We knew he was at the farmhouse."

"This is before."

The timestamp preceded Tessa's detention by four days.

Michael used his own credentials from a homicide workstation.

The query terms were visible.

FENNER / BELL / ZERO / RED FILE

Naomi Bell.

Session Zero.

Lucas Fenner's financial investigation.

Michael had connected them before the farmhouse.

"Assigned reason?" Elena asked.

"Supplemental source verification in Shaw inquiry."

"Was the Shaw inquiry active?"

"Not officially."

"Supervisor approval?"

"Morrison's code appears."

"Did Morrison approve it?"

"He says no."

"Can we prove use of his code?"

"The system accepted it."

Not the same.

Wells pulled out a chair.

"There are three later accesses."

The first occurred six hours after Tessa was freed.

Michael viewed the initial incident report.

The second occurred two days later.

He viewed the evidence inventory and photographs.

The third occurred after the sealed hearing.

He viewed the transcript index but not the transcript.

"Why not the transcript?" Elena asked.

"Access denied. Protective order."

"Did he appeal?"

"No record."

"Alternative route?"

"He met Ruth Calder three days later."

"Evidence?"

"Her calendar. Meeting title: THORNE - AUDIO DEMAND."

Elena looked towards the wall.

The room contained no window.

Only shelves of banker boxes and a ventilation grille that clicked when the fan changed speed.

"Ruth never disclosed that to Hargrove?"

"Hargrove says he learned this morning."

"Ruth's explanation?"

"She will speak after counsel arrives."

"She has counsel?"

"She is counsel."

"Smart people still need independent advice."

Wells almost smiled.

"Desai said the same thing."

The records analyst raised a hand from the terminal.

"I found the source database."

Elena crossed the room.

The metadata field entered the system under a retired county software package called Witness Continuity Manager.

The field list included:

ACTIVE

RELOCATED

DECEASED

RECANED

HOLLOW

"Definition table?" Elena asked.

"Missing from the migration."

"Vendor manuals?"

"Company dissolved."

"Who installed it?"

The analyst opened the procurement record.

A consulting firm named Calder Vale Systems.

Not Ruth Calder.

Not necessarily related.

The project manager was Graham Vale, then an assistant state's attorney.

Now a circuit judge.

Lucas Fenner's investigation had included one of Vale's judicial campaign accounts.

"Do not contact him yet," Elena said.

"Conflict?"

"Preservation first."

Desai entered as Elena spoke.

"Orders are moving," she said. "Cope's house is now a criminal scene pending review. The local department agreed after the cut telephone line."

"Slade?"

"Garage sealed. Vehicle and door motor preserved."

"Caleb Morrow?"

"Last verified activity was seven years ago. But an Illinois hunting licence renewed in person eighteen months ago under his name."

"Photograph?"

"DMV image does not match."

"Identity theft?"

"Or someone maintaining the appearance of life."

Elena looked at the old farmhouse photographs.

One showed the front room after Tessa was released.

A wooden chair stood six feet from the door.

Plastic ties lay near the wall.

A red mark crossed the floorboards where the chair had been dragged.

The photographer captured the evidence without understanding the act.

"Who took the photographs?" Elena asked.

Desai checked.

"Evan Slade."

"He photographed the chair Michael moved."

"If Tessa's account is accurate."

"Yes."

The photograph did not prove who moved it.

It proved the movement occurred before documentation.

Elena returned to the access log.

"Did the recent request include this image?"

"All scene photographs."

"Any download after?"

The analyst opened the activity detail.

One image had been viewed for eleven minutes.

Not the room.

The rear threshold.

A partial shoe print appeared in mud beyond the open door.

The original report called it unsuitable for comparison.

"Enhancement ever attempted?" Elena asked.

"No."

"Do it now. Independent lab."

Desai leaned closer.

"The person who requested the file studied the same image."

"Or left the terminal open."

"You believe that?"

"No. But the log does not record attention. Only duration."

Wells placed another file on the table.

"There is more."

Lucas Fenner's red file had never been recovered.

The prosecution claimed Wesley Crane killed Fenner to obtain it.

Crane denied knowing the file existed.

Tessa said Caleb Morrow took it from her car.

Michael came to the farmhouse asking for it.

Evan Slade later admitted participating in Tessa's detention.

Marian preserved the omitted sentence.

Ruth preserved the recording.

Caleb disappeared.

The file connected every person now at risk.

"What was in it?" Elena asked.

"Financial ledgers, according to Fenner's notes. Also a cassette labelled NB-ZERO."

Naomi Bell.

Michael had believed Session Zero was inside.

"Did he find it?"

"Not at the farmhouse."

"Later?"

"Book one evidence shows he eventually obtained a Session Zero fragment from Naomi. We cannot establish it was the same cassette."

"Then we do not say it was."

Desai's phone vibrated.

She read the message.

"Caleb Morrow's Social Security number was used this morning."

"Where?"

"Urgent-care clinic in Kenosha."

"Person still there?"

"Discharged forty minutes ago."

"Complaint?"

"Chemical burn to left hand."

"Name on camera?"

"Male, approximately fifty. Facial match pending."

Caleb would be fifty-three.

Elena gathered the farmhouse file.

"Vehicle?"

"Camera caught a grey pickup leaving the lot. Wisconsin plate."

"Registered?"

"Plate returns to a school bus."

A false plate.

Not sophisticated.

Prepared.

"Local notification?" Elena asked.

"Discrete locate only," Desai said. "No broadcast of Tessa or the audio."

"Why the burn?"

Wells looked towards the photograph of the farmhouse threshold.

"Maybe someone tried to destroy what he kept."

"Or he did."

Elena placed the image in a clear sleeve.

The partial print showed a heel, two broken tread bars and a smooth outer edge.

A shoe crossing a threshold seven years earlier.

Marian's final words had not yet been recovered from her house.

No one in the room knew she had died answering the same question.

Who opened the door?

At 11:32 a.m., the Kenosha clinic sent the surveillance image.

The man at the desk wore a baseball cap and kept his injured hand inside a plastic grocery bag.

Facial software returned a seventy-eight percent match to Caleb Morrow's licence photograph from nine years earlier.

Not identification.

Enough to look.

As Elena studied the frame, the analyst opened one final access record.

The farmhouse file had been queried again twelve minutes earlier.

This time from a terminal inside the federal building.

The search term contained only two words.

CALDER ORIGINAL.

Continue reading

You have reached the end of this reading sample from *The Hollow Witness*. The complete work continues beyond this excerpt.

The Michael Thorne Series - Book Four